

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 50 Summary

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This lesson focuses on a common but often misunderstood Spanish subjunctive trigger: **describing non-specific or indefinite items or people using relative clauses introduced by “que.”** These constructions consistently require the subjunctive mood.

The Core Rule

When a **non-specific item** is described using a relative clause introduced by **que**, the verb in that clause should be in the **subjunctive**.

Structure:

[Main clause in indicative] + **que** + [verb in the subjunctive]

This structure is used when referring to something or someone **not yet identified, selected, or confirmed to exist**.

Examples: Specific vs. Non-Specific

1. Non-Specific Item → Subjunctive Required

- *Quiero una silla que **sea** cómoda.*
(I want a chair that is comfortable.)
→ The chair is not specified; the speaker doesn't have a particular one in mind.

2. Specific Item → Indicative Used

- *Quiero la silla que **es** cómoda.*
(I want the chair that is comfortable.)
→ The speaker refers to a specific chair already known.

3. Non-Specific House

- *Busco una casa que **dé** al parque.*
(I'm looking for a house that faces the park.)
→ The house is indefinite; subjunctive is used (*dé* from *dar*).

4. Specific House

- *Busco la casa que **da** al parque.*
(I'm looking for the house that faces the park.)
→ A known house is being referred to; indicative is used (*da*).

Application with Common Verbs

This construction appears frequently with verbs like:

- **Querer** (to want)
- **Buscar** (to look for)
- **Necesitar** (to need)
- **Preferir** (to prefer)

These verbs often introduce clauses referring to desired but **unspecified** things or people—thus triggering the subjunctive.

Subject Change and “Que”

As seen in earlier lessons, a **subject change** helps signal the subjunctive.

- *Busco una casa que **tenga** tres recámaras.*
(I’m looking for a house that has three bedrooms.)
→ Two subjects: “I” and “the house.” Subjunctive is used (*tenga*).
 - *Busco la casa que **tiene** tres recámaras.*
(I’m looking for the house that has three bedrooms.)
→ Specific house = indicative (*tiene*).
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Additional Notes on “Buscar” and the Personal “A”

When **buscar** is used with non-specific people, the **personal “a”** is often omitted.

Example:

- *Busco un carpintero que **sepa** hacer muebles.*
(I’m looking for a carpenter who knows how to make furniture.)

But when the person is **specific**, the personal **a** is used:

- *Busco **al** carpintero que **sabe** hacer muebles.*
(I’m looking for the carpenter who knows how to make furniture.)

In cases of uncertainty or optionality, the Royal Spanish Academy (RAE) permits either use with verbs like *buscar* and *encontrar*.

Useful Sentence Starters for Practice

These plug-and-play phrases allow learners to apply the rule consistently:

1. **Busco a alguien que sepa + [infinitive]**
(I'm looking for someone who knows how to...)
Example: *Busco a alguien que sepa tocar la guitarra.*
2. **Busco a alguien que pueda + [infinitive]**
(I'm looking for someone who can...)
Example: *Busco a alguien que pueda trabajar los fines de semana.*

Each of these triggers the **present subjunctive** in the relative clause because the person being described is non-specific.

Summary Table

Type of Reference	Example	Mood
Non-specific item	<i>Quiero una casa que tenga jardín.</i>	Subjunctive
Specific item	<i>Quiero la casa que tiene jardín.</i>	Indicative
Non-specific person	<i>Busco a alguien que pueda ayudarme.</i>	Subjunctive
Specific person	<i>Busco al carpintero que sabe hacer muebles.</i>	Indicative

Conclusion:

This lesson reinforces the concept that when describing **non-specific or unknown people or items**, Spanish requires the **subjunctive mood** in the relative clause. Recognizing the trigger (non-specificity) and subject change helps learners know when to apply the subjunctive. This structure is common in everyday Spanish and essential for expressing needs, preferences, and searches.